Why Torrance Memorial's Depression Scores Are Low, and an Easy Fix

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> **Patients may be getting better, but they aren't given the survey that proves it.**

1 The problem (real Medicare data, 2024)

Torrance Memorial's doctors' network is scored by Medicare on quality. It does great on blood pressure, but poorly on depression.

Top 5%
in the country for blood pressure control

7 in 100
depressed patients counted as recovered after a year
(typical network nationally: 14 in 100)

2 Why it happens

Doctors check for depression with a survey. There's a **short 2-question survey** and a **full 9-question survey**. Only the full survey can show that a patient recovered.

Adults usually get only the short survey. If they're doing better, they never get the full one, so **they can't be counted as recovered.** Teens get the full survey at every checkup.

Adults (short survey first)



12 in 100 got the full survey a year later

2 in 100 counted as recovered

Teens (full survey at every checkup)



76 in 100 got the full survey a year later



67 in 100 counted as recovered

From simulated patient records (real records are private), so this is a strong lead to confirm with Torrance Memorial's own data.

3 The fix: three small changes to the medical-records system

A **Give the full survey a year later** to anyone who had a high score before.

B **Require a depression check at every yearly checkup.** Half of all missed checks happened at checkups.

C **Add a box to record the score** at pregnancy visits.

In the simulation, these raise the share of patients checked from **71% to 80%**, even if only half of visits use them.

4 Why this is the right move

- **Cheap:** no new staff, just system settings.
- **Fast:** results in 1 to 3 months.
- **Easy to track:** if more than about 80% of checkups include the depression check in a month, it's working.
- **First step:** one query on Torrance Memorial's real records to confirm adults mostly get the short survey.

Dashboard: claude.ai/artifact/YaLXFSWQqR4bV7pUkPseua · Full details: github.com/yeonancy56/depression-care-gap-analysis
Real data: Medicare Shared Savings Program results, 2024. Patient data is simulated (no real patients). The 9-question survey is the PHQ-9; the 2-question survey is the PHQ-2; "recovered" means remission (PHQ-9 score below 5).